European Parliament proclaimed the European Day of Remembrance for the victims of all totalitarian and authoritarian regimes, to be held every year on 23 August, the day of the infamous Ribbentrop-Molotov Pact. ‘For many, this fateful day marked the beginning of a cycle of Nazi and Soviet occupation and violence,’ conceded the European commissionaires in 2021[69] and a year later drew parallels with Putin’s war in Ukraine[70] – for a good reason.

But the question of whether the three totalitarian systems were ‘equal’ persists. In fact, the three cannot easily be compared as they did not emerge simultaneously in the same countries, and they were also of very different duration. Comparison may be more valid between, say, Franco’s regime in Spain and Tito’s regime in Yugoslavia. Another difficulty in comparing the different systems arises from the fact that, although there were periods of violent anti-Jewish campaigns in the Soviet Union and also massive forced movements of entire ethnic groups which amounted to little less than genocide, Communism was not, by and large, racist in its ideology, at least not vocally. The enemy deserving extinction was the class enemy – to some this seemed a lesser evil. However, seen from the perspective of an individual (Eastern European) nation, Communism was a central experience that, in some places and with some people, even occasionally overshadowed earlier memories of Nazism and Fascism, the ones which remain the primary historical memories in the West. Cumulative numbers suggest that Communism, in its various incarnations, has been responsible for greater numbers of killings of its opponents worldwide than the other two totalitarian systems, especially when we include its victims in Asia.

This left-leaning electorate in Europe often thought that, at worst, there was a correspondence between American influence in Western Europe and Soviet influence in Eastern Europe. (This is a belief that is still alive and well in some quarters of post-Communist societies.) The other reason for the sympathy or at least the more lenient approach towards Communism was that (Soviet) Russia, as the driving force behind Communism in Eastern Europe, had also been an indispensable ally against Nazism that paid an enormous death toll for the victory – something that Putin has been skilfully using to justify marking out zones of interest in Central and Eastern Europe, and also as an excuse to deliberately play down Stalin’s terror or his early collaboration with Hitler. It has also been a part of the